

China

Booming yet bifurcated exports

Exports, a key engine for growth, beat expectations by a wide margin, led by AI-related and green-tech products. However, low-tech and labor-intensive goods lagged behind. This contributes to a growing divergence across industries. The positive spillover from exports to the labor market is limited.

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- **June: 27% y/y for exports, and 36% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**
- **Bloomberg consensus (Barclays): 19% y/y (20%) for exports, and 26% y/y (24%) for imports**
- **May: 19.4% y/y for exports, and 27.4% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**

China's export growth surged to 27% y/y in June, far exceeding expectations (Bloomberg: 19%; Barclays: 20%) and accelerating from 19% in May. The stronger exports partially offset weakened domestic demand. We expect exports to continue to benefit from the global AI capex investment cycle and the ongoing global energy transition, providing an important buffer for growth.

However, similar to the broader bifurcation in the macro economy, the export data also point to a K-shaped recovery. Export strength continues to be driven by high-tech products, particularly AI-related and green-tech goods, while low-tech and labor-intensive sectors (~15% of total exports) lag behind, with exports of footwear and toys remaining in contraction.

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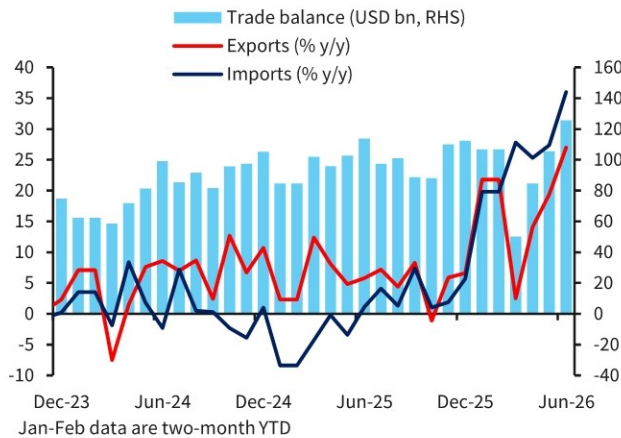
We believe this K-shaped export recovery is contributing to a growing divergence across industries: rising profits and stronger pricing power in high-tech sectors, such as semiconductors and electronics, versus declining profits and persistent price pressures in traditional industries, including textiles and household consumer goods. This trend has been clearly reflected in the recent manufacturing PMI data (see: [China: Modest improvement with sectoral divergence](#), 30 June 2026).

Moreover, as the strength in headline exports is largely concentrated in capital-intensive industries, we believe the positive spillover from exports to the domestic labor market has been limited. As a result, the export boom is unlikely to translate into a rapid recovery in household income or consumption, which explains the continued softness in domestic demand.

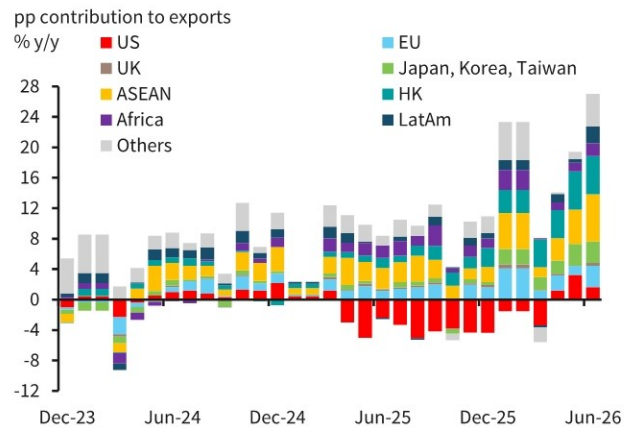
- On AI-related products, exports of semiconductors (~8% of China's total exports YTD) rose 122% y/y in June, while exports of automatic data processing equipment and related parts (~7% of China's total exports YTD) increased 66%. We estimate that these two categories together contributed ~8pp to headline exports growth, which comprises over 40% of total exports growth of 17.6% YTD. For context, China accounts for over 30% of global export value in critical AI-related products, well above Korea (~6%), - including electronic chips, computers, semiconductor components, electrical boards and chip-making equipment.
- Turning to green-tech, the ongoing Middle East tension and renewed energy supply shock is fuelling Chinese growth by boosting demand for its renewable energy-tech exports. YTD exports data showed strong, double-digit growth in these segments, including EVs (+71% y/y), wind turbines (+49% y/y), lithium batteries (+45% y/y), transformers (+33% y/y) and solar cells (+26%). We think a prolonged period of geopolitical tensions will accelerate the global green transition, which will ultimately benefit China as the world's leading green-technology powerhouse given the low costs and high quality green products and technologies.

Details of June export data

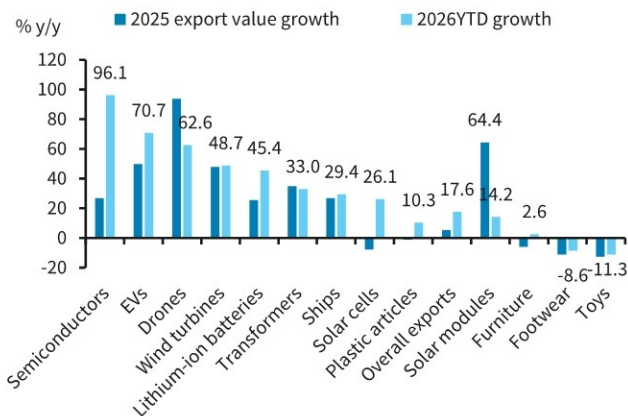
- **By destination:** Export growth strengthened across most major trading partners. Regional trade remained particularly strong, with shipments to Asean surging 34.5% y/y, which was the fastest pace in five years with a record-high monthly export value of USD78.3bn, contributing 6.2pp to headline export growth. Exports to Japan, Korea, and Taiwan also edged higher (June: 28.1% y/y, May: 27.5%). Shipments to Africa and Latin America accelerated notably from May, growing by around 28% y/y, while exports to the EU (June: 18.5%, May: 7.6%) and the UK (June: 16.6%, May: 1.7%) also strengthened. Trade flows between the US and China continued to normalize. Although export growth to the US moderated to 14% y/y from 35.4% previously, export value reached USD43.5bn, the highest level since February. On a sequential basis, exports to the US rose 11.4% m/m in June, following a 6.2% increase in May.
- **By product:** Major export categories accelerated in June. Semiconductor exports value surged 122% in June, following a noticeable 111% increase in May. Auto exports remained resilient, rising 70% y/y, up from the 39% increase in May. Exports of mechanical and electrical products grew 34% y/y, up from 27% previously, while home appliance exports continued to expand (June: 15%, May: 9%). Exports of furniture, general equipment and machinery also accelerated in June.

FIGURE 1. June exports accelerated further...

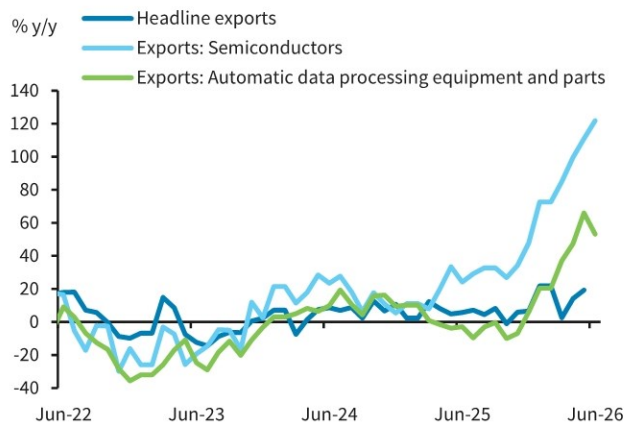
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ... with shipments to the Asean surging the most in five years

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. Strong exports were led by AI-related and green-tech products...

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. ...with especially a 122% gain in semi conductors exports in June

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

June imports posted another strong gain

Imports continued to outperform expectations amid the global AI investment boom. Headline imports rose 36%/y/y in June, well above consensus forecast of 26% and accelerating from 27% in May. The strength was driven primarily by mechanical and electrical products, imports of which surged 47.5%/y/y, the fastest pace in more than 16 years. Agricultural imports also recovered, with soybean imports returning to growth, while commodity imports slowed noticeably, expanding by around 5%/y/y after averaging 15% growth in April-May.

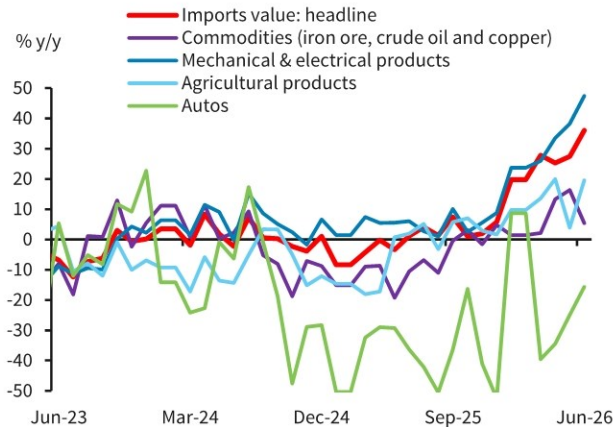
On a volume basis, energy-related imports showed mixed trends. Crude oil imports fell sharply by 41%/y/y to 29.3mn tons, the lowest level since October 2016, despite more favorable oil prices during the month. The decline came against continued inventory drawdowns, with China's crude stockpiles falling to 1.2bn barrels by end-June from 1.25bn barrels at end-April, according to Kpler. Looking ahead, there are signs of a recovery in crude demand. Bloomberg reported that some Chinese refiners returned to the market for discounted Middle Eastern crude in early July as producers sought to clear cargo backlogs, with purchases from Saudi Arabia, Iraq, and

the UAE¹. In addition, authorities have released fuel export curbs and reportedly instructed major refiners to maintain high fuel output amid recent Middle East tensions², factors that could support crude imports in the coming months.

In contrast, coal imports surged 29.5% y/y to 42.8mn tons, a five-month high, following tighter domestic coal supply following recent mine-safety inspections. Natural gas imports also improved, rising 3.7% y/y in June from flat growth in May.

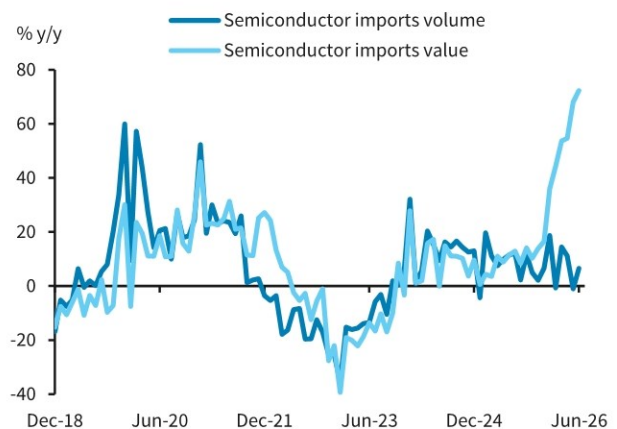
Imports of industrial materials were mixed. Iron ore import volume growth rebounded, while copper import growth moderated to 3% y/y from 4.3% previously. Soybean imports increased 10.5% y/y in June after declining 15% in May, with monthly arrivals reaching 13.5mn metric tons, the second-highest level on record after May 2025. Demand for US soybeans appears to be improving. Media reports indicate that China made its largest single-day purchase of US soybeans since November on 8 July³. This follows agreements to expand agricultural trade reached after the mid-May Trump-Xi summit, with the US stating that China would purchase at least USD17bn of US agricultural products annually during 2026-28, in addition to previously announced soybean commitments.

FIGURE 5. Imports of mechanical and electrical products accelerated...



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. ...with visible increase in semiconductor import value



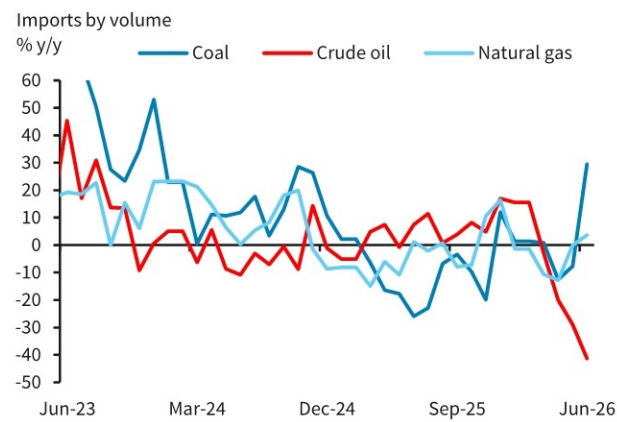
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

¹ "China's Oil Imports Poised to Recover as Stockpiling Returns (1)", Bloomberg, 13 July 2026

² "China Allows Major Exports of Diesel and Gasoline This Month", Bloomberg, 8 July 2026 "China Tells Refiners to Keep Fuel Output High as Iran War Drags", Bloomberg, 11 July 2026

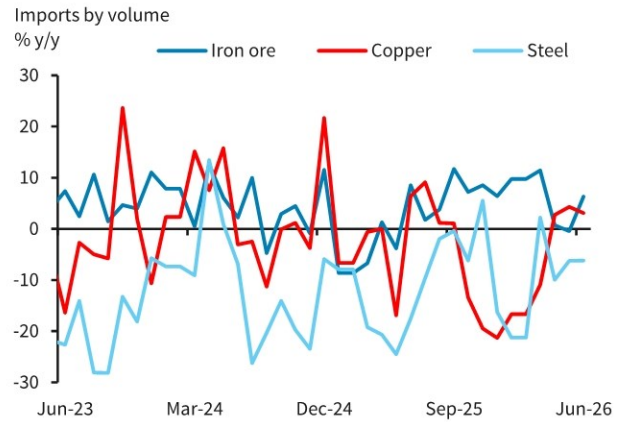
³ "Large Daily Order for US Soybeans Appears to Show Success of Xi-Trump Pact", SMP, 10 July 2026

FIGURE 7. A notable fell in crude imports



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 8. Imports of industrial materials were mixed



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

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